

AI Safety and Professional Boundaries in Accounting

• AI Governance

• Audit

• Legal

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THE QUESTION

Where does AI assistance end and professional judgment begin?

THE SHORT ANSWER

AI assistance is safe in professional accounting only when its boundaries are designed: it clarifies when facts are missing, limits itself to what sources support, and escalates what needs a person. Pair that with risk-based decision rights, oversight that engages reviewers, and monitoring that shows when boundaries drift.

FOUR KEY IDEAS

1 Assistance is a spectrum

Explain, locate, analyze, recommend, decide. Set the highest permitted level for each workflow in advance, and keep the decision itself with qualified people.

2 Clarify, limit, escalate

Three ways a system declines to simply answer. Each is specified, tested and recorded, and each beats a confident answer that should not have been given.

3 Decision rights follow risk

Higher-risk matters need more senior acceptance and fuller evidence. Unwritten decision rights default to whoever is closest to the screen.

4 Oversight must be real

Show evidence first, surface uncertainty and require engagement. Plan reviewer capacity, or review degrades into rubber-stamping.

WHO SHOULD READ THE FULL PAPER

AI governance owners, audit and risk leaders, legal and compliance teams, and the professionals who will rely on AI assistance in accounting work.

INSIDE THE FULL PAPER

What the full paper covers

#	SECTION	WHAT IT ANSWERS
1	The professional-judgment line	The line between assistance and judgment is not binary, and treating it as binary is how most boundary failures begin.
2	How AI assistance fails at the boundary	Boundary failures are rarely dramatic. They are small overreaches that pass review because nothing looked wrong.
3	Clarify, limit, escalate	A well-bounded system has three ways of not simply answering.
4	A worked example: one question, three outcomes	The same starting question can legitimately lead to three different outcomes, depending on the facts and the risk.
5	Risk classification and decision rights	Behavior should vary with risk, and the people allowed to accept an answer should vary with it too.
6	Human oversight that actually works	Putting a person in the loop is not the same as having oversight.
7	Designing the experience of a boundary	A boundary that users experience as an obstacle will be worked around.
8	Governance, accountability and legal considerations	A policy gives the boundaries force. It should be specific enough to apply and short enough to be read.
9	Monitoring and incident response	Boundaries drift. What you measure after launch tells you whether they still hold.

QUESTIONS THIS PAPER HELPS YOU ASK

☐	What is the system for, what is it not for, and where is that written?
☐	Does it ask for missing facts and state assumptions instead of answering anyway?
☐	Which matters are escalated, to whom, with what context?
☐	Who may accept output at each risk tier?
☐	What do we monitor to know whether boundaries still hold?

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